ADB Safegate

Business Development Dossier

Industry	**Airport Technology**
Revenue	**$440M**
Employees	**900**
Ideal Customer Profile Score	**65**

ICP SCORING MODEL


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ICP = Signals + Revenue + Employees + Fit   (max 100)
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Signals (0-35)	Top 4 signals scored; each = base(60%) + recency bonus <30d: 40% | <90d: 30% | <180d: 20% | older: 10%
Revenue (0-25)	$500M-$10B sweet spot -> 70-100% of 25 pts Below $500M -> pro-rata x 0.5 | Above $10B -> 60%
Employees (0-20)	2,000+ preferred (70-100%) | 500-2K partial (50-70%) Below 500 -> pro-rata x 0.3
Fit (0-20)	High-fit types: reorg, transformation, M&A, hiring, funding, partnership -> 5 pts ea (max 12) + diversity 2/type (max 8)

Prepared March 26, 2026

McChrystal Group

Leadership Advisory & Organizational Effectiveness

SECTION 1

Organization Snapshot

Legal Name	ADB SAFEGATE N.V.
Headquarters	Zaventem, Belgium
Founded	1920

Ownership

Private - owned by The Carlyle Group (acquired July 2017 from PAI Partners for ~$1B). CPP Investments (Canada Pension Plan) as co-investor

Footprint

175+ countries, 2,700+ airports. Regional operations: Americas (US-led), EMEA, Asia-Pacific. Smart factory in Liege, Belgium

SECTION 1b

Company Overview

ADB Safegate is the global leader in airfield visual guidance and airport performance solutions, serving 2,700+ airports across 175+ countries. Owned by The Carlyle Group since 2017 ($1B acquisition), the company is executing a platform transformation from hardware vendor to integrated digital provider via Airside 4.0 - integrating gate, airfield, tower, and digital solutions. With ~900 employees managing simultaneous marquee contracts (JFK T1, Munich, Western Sydney, Vienna), ADB Safegate is approaching PE exit timeline after 9 years of Carlyle ownership.

SECTION 2

Financial Health & Growth Stage

Understanding ADB Safegate's financial position and trajectory is critical to framing any engagement conversation.

Revenue: ~EUR 400M at 2017 acquisition; reportedly ~$750M as of 2025 [INFERRED - represents ~80%+ growth over hold period]

Profitability: Not publicly disclosed. 2025 refinancing (EUR 500M term loan + EUR 184M equity injection + EUR 100M HoldCo PIK) suggests investing for growth rather than near-term EBITDA maximization

Growth stage: Late-stage PE portfolio company transitioning from hardware to integrated digital platform

Pressures: 9-year PE hold (exceeding typical 5-7 year), integration of multiple acquisitions (All Weather, Liberty, AviBit, ERNI, Lucebit), competition from Honeywell/Siemens/Thales, delayed airport projects now hitting simultaneously

Tailwinds: Global airport infrastructure boom (Western Sydney, JFK T1, Munich), Airside 4.0 creating recurring digital revenue, sustainability mandates driving LED retrofits

SECTION 3

Leadership Team Profiles

The following contacts are recommended as primary outreach targets - champion-level leaders who feel the organizational pain daily and can sponsor McChrystal internally.

Joe Pokoj - COO / CEO Americas [PRIORITY TARGET]

US-based. Dual role suggests lean organization

Outreach rationale: Dual-hatted operator who feels lean staffing and cross-product coordination pain daily. Pragmatic buyer - delivering JFK T1 while coordinating 900-person global operation

Thorben Burghardt - CTO & EVP Business Lines [PRIORITY TARGET]

Technology and product strategy. Leads Airside 4.0 development

Outreach rationale: Owns Airside 4.0 platform integration - requires merging legacy product lines (lighting, gates, tower, digital) into unified offering. Organizational design challenge as much as technology

Additional leadership team members relevant to the engagement:

Laurent Dubois - CEO

Belgian; Vrije Universiteit Brussels (Economics). Former CEO GE Healthcare Partners; former Partner at McKinsey & Company

Christian Onselaere - Chairman

Built ADB SAFEGATE through PAI and Carlyle transitions. Institutional memory

Regardt Willer - CMO & VP Business Development

Marketing, brand strategy, business development. Won 2025 Marketing award for Airside 4.0 campaign

SECTION 4

Organizational Culture & Structure

Culture and structure are often where McChrystal Group finds the deepest leverage. The following signals indicate how ADB Safegate operates today and where friction exists.

Organizational Structure

Global but fragmented: ~900 employees across 175+ countries means extremely thin coverage. Regional heads (Americas, Asia) operate with significant autonomy by necessity. Product line silos likely persist from ADB (lighting) + Safegate (gates) merger plus multiple acquisitions

Culture Signals

Glassdoor: 3.8/5.0 (99 reviews); 72% recommend. Culture 3.8/5.0

Key signal: 'Fast-paced work environment, typical for companies owned by a private equity company, and not everyone is fitting in to the new culture'

Concerns: 'Very lean with little training, requiring employees to figure things out on their own'; onboarding needs improvement; pay could be better

Positives: Nice atmosphere, caring/supportive people, good work-life balance

PE pace vs. capacity: Classic tension - high expectations with thin staffing. Employees explicitly cite PE ownership as cultural pace driver

CEO from McKinsey/GE: Laurent Dubois' background suggests data-driven, process-oriented style - potentially at odds with engineering-heavy, product-focused legacy culture

SECTION 5

Recent News & Trigger Events

The following developments from the past 18 months create urgency and provide natural conversation entry points for engaging ADB Safegate.

1. 2025-01-01 - Triple win at 2025 Airport Technology Excellence Awards (Marketing, R&D, Social Impact)
Validates Airside 4.0 strategy but creates pressure to deliver across lean global workforce

2. 2024-12-01 - Munich Airport awards next-gen controller working position contract with AI and Airside 4.0
Major reference customer requiring cross-product-line coordination

3. 2025-06-01 - JFK New Terminal One: comprehensive Airside 4.0 deployment including first-in-US Follow-the-Greens
Highest-profile project in company history. Execution risk is existential - failure at JFK damages brand globally

4. 2025-01-01 - Carlyle sponsors EUR 500M+ refinancing (term loan, equity injection, HoldCo PIK)
Financial restructuring after 8+ years signals either exit preparation or growth recapitalization. Creates organizational urgency

5. 2025-06-01 - Western Sydney International Airport contract - Australia's largest airfield lighting contract
Another greenfield Airside 4.0 deployment stretching delivery capacity

SECTION 6

McChrystal Fit Assessment

> *Strong organizational fit (platform transformation, merger integration, PE pressure) and clear McChrystal match. Moderated by: company size below typical ICP sweet spot, private PE-owned with limited advisory budget, CEO's McKinsey default, Carlyle exit timeline uncertainty. However, if $750M revenue is accurate, it's within range, and impact at this scale would be transformational*

Primary Problem

A ~900-person company executing platform transformation (Airside 4.0) requiring integration of multiple legacy product lines - while simultaneously delivering marquee global contracts (JFK, Munich, Western Sydney, Vienna) - under PE ownership pressure as Carlyle approaches/exceeds typical hold period. Gap between strategic ambition (integrated platform) and organizational capacity (lean, fragmented, legacy-siloed)

Best McChrystal Capability Fit

Cross-functional alignment for integrated Airside 4.0 delivery; Team of Teams for lean global coordination (900 people, 175 countries); organizational maturity for PE exit; leadership alignment under PE pressure

Likely Objections to Engagement

We're too small for McChrystal
CEO is former McKinsey partner - he has consulting relationships
Carlyle may be preparing for exit - can't commit long-term

Competitive Advisory Landscape

McKinsey: CEO is former partner - possible existing relationship
Carlyle portfolio operations team (internal)
Boutique aviation consulting firms
None address cross-product-line organizational design

SECTION 7

Conversation Entry Points

These questions are designed for a Senior Partner's first conversation. Each opens a thread that naturally leads to McChrystal Group's capabilities without a direct pitch.

1. Airside 4.0 is brilliant technology - but delivering integrated airport solutions requires your lighting, gate, tower, and digital teams to work as one. How is the organization keeping up with the platform's ambition?

Platform vs. organization gap

2. After 9 years of Carlyle ownership, the organization you present to a buyer matters as much as the technology. How are you thinking about demonstrating organizational maturity as part of your value story?

PE exit readiness - positions operating model as enterprise value driver

3. You're delivering marquee contracts at JFK, Munich, Western Sydney, and Vienna simultaneously - with roughly 900 people. What's the organizational model that lets you execute at this quality without burning people out?

Lean global execution challenge

Recommended Meeting Framing

Position as 'operating model advisory for PE-backed platform transformation' - how a lean global organization coordinates across product lines and regions. Emphasize impact at scale (900 people, 175 countries = every improvement matters disproportionately).

SECTION 8

Brand Insights & Market Positioning

Brand strategy reveals organizational priorities and coordination challenges. The following analysis connects ADB Safegate's market positioning to potential McChrystal engagement opportunities.

Brand: Niche market leader - world's #1 in airfield visual guidance, serving 2,700+ airports. Not in broad brand indexes but dominant within category.

Competitive standing: Leader in airfield lighting and gate management (Safedock). Emerging competitor to Indra, Thales, Frequentis in ATC tower. Competing with much larger Honeywell, Siemens for broader airport solutions.

Evolution: From hardware vendor ('we sell airfield lights') to integrated digital platform ('we deliver Airside 4.0 - the operating system for airport operations'). Brand says 'integrated platform' but organization still structured around legacy product lines.

Threats: Big tech encroachment (Honeywell, Siemens, Thales); customer lock-in concerns; marquee contract delivery risk (JFK/Western Sydney are brand-defining); PE exit brand continuity.

McChrystal connection: Brand promises integrated performance - but org structure reflects legacy product silos. McChrystal builds the organizational capability to match the platform vision.

SECTION 9

Deep McChrystal Group Fit Analysis

This is the strategic case for pursuing ADB Safegate. It synthesizes findings from all previous sections into a comprehensive engagement thesis with specific fit dimensions, expected outcomes, stakeholder mapping, and a phased pursuit strategy.

9a. Fit Dimensions

Dim 1: Product Line Integration for Platform Delivery - Assembled from ADB (lighting) + Safegate (gates) + All Weather + Liberty + AviBit/ERNI. Each retains engineering culture. Airside 4.0 requires integrated delivery. McKinsey redesigns org chart; McChrystal builds operating rhythm and trust that lets diverse teams work together.

Dim 2: Lean Global Coordination - 900 people, 175 countries. Every coordination failure has outsized impact. Glassdoor confirms: 'very lean, figure things out on your own.' McChrystal builds information-sharing and decision-making for lean organizations at scale - same approach as Special Operations (small teams, global theaters, perfect coordination).

Dim 3: PE Exit Organizational Readiness - 9 years under Carlyle. A company dependent on heroic individual efforts is worth less than one with scalable, repeatable operating model. McChrystal builds the operating model that increases enterprise value.

Dim 4: High-Stakes Execution - Airport operations are safety-critical, time-pressured. Products are safety-critical. Mirrors military operating environments where McChrystal's methodology was developed.

9b. Cumulative Case

PE hold exceeded (9 years) -> exit pressure -> demands organizational maturity -> during platform transformation (Airside 4.0) -> requiring product-line integration -> with ~900 people across 175 countries -> under simultaneous marquee contract pressure (JFK, Munich, Western Sydney, Vienna) -> in safety-critical environment -> where execution failure is existential.

Revenue: Phase 1: $250K-$400K (exec committee + delivery model) | Phase 2: $400K-$600K (regional cascade + exit readiness) | Phase 3: $200K-$350K/year | Total: $850K-$1.35M

9c. Enterprise Issues

1. Legacy product line silos blocking platform delivery
2. Thin global staffing creating single points of failure
3. PE pace vs. organizational capacity mismatch
4. Simultaneous marquee contract delivery risk (JFK, Munich, Western Sydney, Vienna)
5. CEO background creating consulting dependency risk (former McKinsey partner)
6. Onboarding and knowledge transfer gaps
7. Regional autonomy vs. platform consistency

9d. Expected Outcomes

1. Cross-product-line delivery model - project cycle time reduced 20-30%; coordination issues down 50%
2. Global operating rhythm - regional escalations to HQ reduced 40%; 80% of cross-regional issues resolved within 48 hours
3. Executive committee alignment - decision cycle reduced 30%; zero conflicting directives
4. Organizational maturity for PE exit - operating model rated 'investor-ready'; contributes to 0.5-1.0x EBITDA multiple improvement [INFERRED]
5. Marquee contract delivery assurance - 100% within 10% of timeline; zero critical quality incidents
6. Knowledge transfer system - new hire time-to-productivity reduced 30%; critical knowledge mapped within 12 months

9e. Key Stakeholders

CEO Office

Leader: Laurent Dubois
Title: CEO
Relevance: Decision-maker. Former McKinsey - differentiate positioning

Board

Leader: Christian Onselaere
Title: Chairman
Relevance: Institutional memory, board influence

Operations/Americas

Leader: Joe Pokoj
Title: COO/CEO Americas
Relevance: PRIMARY TARGET - feels execution pain daily

Technology/Products

Leader: Thorben Burghardt
Title: CTO & EVP
Relevance: SECONDARY TARGET - platform integration owner

Finance

Leader: Dominic Cote-Vaillancourt
Title: CFO
Relevance: Budget holder, exit prep

Marketing

Leader: Regardt Willer
Title: CMO & VP BD
Relevance: Brand-organization gap awareness

Carlyle Group

Leader: Operating partners
Title: PE ownership
Relevance: May recommend/fund advisory

9f. Opportunity Thesis

Why Now: PE hold exceeded + marquee contract delivery peak + platform transformation midstream. Next 18 months determine whether Airside 4.0 is genuine platform business (premium valuation) or repackaged hardware (commodity valuation).

Why McChrystal: Former McKinsey CEO knows McKinsey's strengths and limitations. McKinsey designs blueprints; McChrystal builds team coordination for execution. 900 people in 175 countries in safety-critical environment = Special Operations analogy is especially apt.

Phased Engagement: Phase 1 (Q2-Q3 2026, $250K-$400K): Exec committee + Airside 4.0 delivery model | Phase 2 (Q4 2026-Q1 2027, $400K-$600K): Regional cascade + PE exit readiness | Phase 3 ($200K-$350K/year): Ongoing advisory + transition support

Pursuit Map: Thread 1: Joe Pokoj (COO/Americas) via JFK delivery pressure. Thread 2: Thorben Burghardt (CTO) via platform integration challenge. Thread 3: Warm introduction via Carlyle Group network - 'we help PE portfolio companies build operating model maturity that increases exit valuation.'